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## Patent Public Search | Text View

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| United States Patent | 12405470            |
| Kind Code            | B2                  |
| Date of Patent       | September 02, 2025  |
| Inventor(s)          | Osterhout; Ralph F. |

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### See-through computer display systems with vision correction and increased content density

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#### Abstract

Provided herein are examples of an impact resistant glass-waveguide configuration for a see-through head-worn computer display. In embodiments, the configuration includes vision correction and content density control through electrochromic and/or photochromic systems.

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| <b>Appl. No.:</b> | <b>18/420611</b>                                    |
| <b>Filed:</b>     | <b>January 23, 2024</b>                             |

#### Prior Publication Data

|                            |                         |
|----------------------------|-------------------------|
| <b>Document Identifier</b> | <b>Publication Date</b> |
| US 20240160021 A1          | May. 16, 2024           |

#### Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc US 17528059 20211116 US 11988837 child-doc US 18420611  
continuation parent-doc US 16393851 20190424 US 11204501 20211221 child-doc US 17528059  
us-provisional-application US 62661720 20180424

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#### Publication Classification

**Int. Cl.: G02F1/153 (20060101); G02B1/14 (20150101); G02B27/01 (20060101); G02C7/10 (20060101); G02F1/163 (20060101)**

**U.S. Cl.:**

**CPC G02B27/0172 (20130101); G02B1/14 (20150115); G02C7/101 (20130101); G02C7/102 (20130101); G02F1/163 (20130101); G02B2027/0118 (20130101); G02B2027/0174 (20130101); G02B2027/0178 (20130101)**

## **Field of Classification Search**

**CPC:** G02F (1/153)

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## **Background/Summary**

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATION (1) This application is a continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 17/528,059, filed Nov. 16, 2021, which is a continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 16/393,851, filed on Apr. 24, 2019, now U.S. Pat. No. 11,204,501, issued Dec. 21, 2021, which claims the benefit under 35 U.S.C. § 119(e) of U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 62/661,720, filed Apr. 24, 2018, the contents of all of which are incorporated by reference herein in their entirety.

### **BACKGROUND**

#### **Field of the Invention**

(1) This invention relates to see-through computer display systems with vision correction and/or increased content density.

#### **Description of Related Art**

(2) Head mounted displays (HMDs) and particularly HMDs that provide a see-through view of the

environment are valuable instruments. The presentation of content in the see-through display can be a complicated operation when attempting to ensure that the user experience is optimized. Improved systems and methods for presenting content in the see-through display can improve the user experience.

## SUMMARY

(3) Aspects of the present invention relate to methods and systems for the see-through computer display systems with waveguides that include a vision corrective and increased content density by reducing scene light.

(4) These and other systems, methods, objects, features, and advantages of the present invention will be apparent to those skilled in the art from the following detailed description of the preferred embodiment and the drawings. All documents mentioned herein are hereby incorporated in their entirety by reference.

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## Description

### BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) Embodiments are described with reference to the following Figures.

(2) The same numbers may be used throughout to reference like features and components that are shown in the Figures:

(3) FIG. 1 illustrates a head-worn computer ecosystem in accordance with the principles of the present invention.

(4) FIG. 2 illustrates a head worn computing system with optical system in accordance with the principles of the present invention.

(5) FIG. 3 illustrates an exemplary image transfer module in accordance with the principles of the present invention.

(6) FIG. 4 illustrates a waveguide construction with vision correction and increased content density through controlled scene light transmission in accordance with the principles of the present invention.

(7) While the invention has been described in connection with certain preferred embodiments, other embodiments would be understood by one of ordinary skill in the art and are encompassed herein.

### DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE PREFERRED EMBODIMENT(S)

(8) Aspects of the present invention relate to head-worn computing (“HWC”) systems. HWC involves, in some instances, a system that mimics the appearance of head-worn glasses or sunglasses. The glasses may be a fully developed computing platform, such as including computer displays presented in each of the lenses of the glasses to the eyes of the user. In embodiments, the lenses and displays may be configured to allow a person wearing the glasses to see the environment through the lenses while also seeing, simultaneously, digital imagery, which forms an overlaid image that is perceived by the person as a digitally augmented image of the environment, or augmented reality (“AR”).

(9) HWC involves more than just placing a computing system on a person's head. The system may need to be designed as a lightweight, compact and fully functional computer display, such as wherein the computer display includes a high resolution digital display that provides a high level of emersion comprised of the displayed digital content and the see-through view of the environmental surroundings. User interfaces and control systems suited to the HWC device may be required that are unlike those used for a more conventional computer such as a laptop. For the HWC and associated systems to be most effective, the glasses may be equipped with sensors to determine environmental conditions, geographic location, relative positioning to other points of interest, objects identified by imaging and movement by the user or other users in a connected group, and the like. The HWC may then change the mode of operation to match the conditions, location,

positioning, movements, and the like, in a method generally referred to as a contextually aware HWC. The glasses also may need to be connected, wirelessly or otherwise, to other systems either locally or through a network. Controlling the glasses may be achieved through the use of an external device, automatically through contextually gathered information, through user gestures captured by the glasses sensors, and the like. Each technique may be further refined depending on the software application being used in the glasses. The glasses may further be used to control or coordinate with external devices that are associated with the glasses.

(10) Referring to FIG. 1, an overview of the HWC system **100** is presented. As shown, the HWC system **100** comprises a HWC **102**, which in this instance is configured as glasses to be worn on the head with sensors such that the HWC **102** is aware of the objects and conditions in the environment **114**. In this instance, the HWC **102** also receives and interprets control inputs such as gestures and movements **116**. The HWC **102** may communicate with external user interfaces **104**. The external user interfaces **104** may provide a physical user interface to take control instructions from a user of the HWC **102** and the external user interfaces **104** and the HWC **102** may communicate bi-directionally to affect the user's command and provide feedback to the external device **108**. The HWC **102** may also communicate bi-directionally with externally controlled or coordinated local devices **108**. For example, an external user interface **104** may be used in connection with the HWC **102** to control an externally controlled or coordinated local device **108**. The externally controlled or coordinated local device **108** may provide feedback to the HWC **102** and a customized GUI may be presented in the HWC **102** based on the type of device or specifically identified device **108**. The HWC **102** may also interact with remote devices and information sources **112** through a network connection **110**. Again, the external user interface **104** may be used in connection with the HWC **102** to control or otherwise interact with any of the remote devices **108** and information sources **112** in a similar way as when the external user interfaces **104** are used to control or otherwise interact with the externally controlled or coordinated local devices **108**. Similarly, HWC **102** may interpret gestures **116** (e.g. captured from forward, downward, upward, rearward facing sensors such as camera(s), range finders, IR sensors, etc.) or environmental conditions sensed in the environment **114** to control either local or remote devices **108** or **112**.

(11) We will now describe each of the main elements depicted on FIG. 1 in more detail; however, these descriptions are intended to provide general guidance and should not be construed as limiting. Additional description of each element may also be further described herein.

(12) The HWC **102** is a computing platform intended to be worn on a person's head. The HWC **102** may take many different forms to fit many different functional requirements. In some situations, the HWC **102** will be designed in the form of conventional glasses. The glasses may or may not have active computer graphics displays. In situations where the HWC **102** has integrated computer displays the displays may be configured as see-through displays such that the digital imagery can be overlaid with respect to the user's view of the environment **114**. There are a number of see-through optical designs that may be used, including ones that have a reflective display (e.g. LCoS, DLP), emissive displays (e.g. OLED, micro-LED), holographic surfaces, TIR waveguides, and the like. In embodiments, lighting systems used in connection with the display optics may be solid state lighting systems, such as LED, OLED, quantum dot, quantum dot LED, etc. In addition, the optical configuration may be monocular or binocular. It may also include vision corrective optical components. In other embodiments, the HWC **102** may be in the form of a helmet with a see-through shield, sunglasses, safety glasses, goggles, a mask, fire helmet with see-through shield, police helmet with see through shield, military helmet with see-through shield, utility form customized to a certain work task (e.g. inventory control, logistics, repair, maintenance, etc.), and the like.

(13) The HWC **102** may also have a number of integrated computing facilities, such as an integrated processor, integrated power management, communication structures (e.g. cell net, WiFi,

Bluetooth, local area connections, mesh connections, remote connections (e.g. client server, etc.)), and the like. The HWC **102** may also have a number of positional awareness sensors, such as GPS, electronic compass, altimeter, tilt sensor, IMU, and the like. It may also have other sensors such as a camera, rangefinder, hyper-spectral camera, Geiger counter, microphone, spectral illumination detector, temperature sensor, chemical sensor, biologic sensor, moisture sensor, ultrasonic sensor, and the like.

(14) The HWC **102** may also have integrated control technologies. The integrated control technologies may be contextual based control, passive control, active control, user control, and the like. For example, the HWC **102** may have an integrated sensor (e.g. camera) that captures user hand or body gestures **116** such that the integrated processing system can interpret the gestures and generate control commands for the HWC **102**. In another example, the HWC **102** may have sensors that detect movement (e.g. a nod, head shake, and the like) including accelerometers, gyros and other inertial measurements, where the integrated processor may interpret the movement and generate a control command in response. The HWC **102** may also automatically control itself based on measured or perceived environmental conditions. For example, if it is bright in the environment the HWC **102** may increase the brightness or contrast of the displayed image. In embodiments, the integrated control technologies may be mounted on the HWC **102** such that a user can interact with it directly. For example, the HWC **102** may have a button(s), touch capacitive interface, and the like.

(15) As described herein, the HWC **102** may be in communication with external user interfaces **104**. The external user interfaces may come in many different forms. For example, a cell phone screen may be adapted to take user input for control of an aspect of the HWC **102**. The external user interface may be a dedicated UI, such as a keyboard, touch surface, button(s), joy stick, and the like. In embodiments, the external controller may be integrated into another device such as a ring, watch, bike, car, and the like. In each case, the external user interface **104** may include sensors (e.g. IMU, accelerometers, compass, altimeter, and the like) to provide additional input for controlling the HWD **104**.

(16) As described herein, the HWC **102** may control or coordinate with other local devices **108**. The external devices **108** may be an audio device, visual device, vehicle, cell phone, computer, and the like. For instance, the local external device **108** may be another HWC **102**, where information may then be exchanged between the separate HWCs **108**.

(17) Similar to the way the HWC **102** may control or coordinate with local devices **106**, the HWC **102** may control or coordinate with remote devices **112**, such as the HWC **102** communicating with the remote devices **112** through a network **110**. Again, the form of the remote device **112** may have many forms. Included in these forms is another HWC **102**. For example, each HWC **102** may communicate its GPS position such that all the HWCs **102** know where all of HWC **102** are located.

(18) FIG. 2 illustrates a HWC **102** with an optical system that includes an image production module **202** and an image transfer optical module **204**. While the modules **202** and **204** will generally be described as separate modules, it should be understood that this is illustrative only and the present invention includes other physical configurations, such as that when the two modules are combined into a single module or where the elements making up the two modules are configured into more than two modules. In embodiments, the image production module **202** includes a computer controlled display (e.g. LCoS, DLP, OLED, micro-LED etc.) and be arranged to transmit or project image light to the image transfer optical module **204**. In embodiments, the image transfer optical module **204** includes eye delivery optics that are configured to receive the image light and deliver the image light to the eye of a wearer of the HWC. The transfer optical module may include reflective, refractive, holographic, TIR, etc. surfaces. It should be noted that while the optical modules **202** and **204** are illustrated in one side of the HWC such that image light can be delivered to one eye of the wearer, that it is envisioned by the present invention that embodiments will

contain two image light delivery systems, one for each eye. It should also be noted that while the image production module **202** is depicted in FIG. **2** as above the image transfer module **204**, the inventors envision other configurations as well. The image may be projected to the image transfer module **204** from the top, bottom side, at a corner, from behind, from the front, etc. These configurations may depend on what optics are included in the module.

(19) FIG. **3** illustrates a specific type of image transfer module **204**. It illustrates a waveguide with image light direction surfaces **302** to direct the image light within the waveguide. There are a number of different types of waveguides with image light direction surfaces: holographic, single layer holographic, multi-layer holographic, thick film holographic, outer surface holographic, prism, surface relief, active holographic, etc. Reference, which is incorporated herein, is made to <https://uploadvr.com/waveguides-smartglasses/to> to provide some examples of waveguides with direction surfaces. In the example illustrated in FIG. **3**, an image production module **202** projects light into an area of the waveguide **302** that includes an input surface **304** adapted to re-direct the image light internally, through total internal reflection (TIR), to a fold surface **308** that redirects the image light within the waveguide **302** to an output surface **310** that is adapted to re-direct the light out of the waveguide **302** towards a user's eye. The input surface and output surface, in embodiments, are further designed to expand the image light such that, once redirected out of the waveguide **302**, it forms a large field of view for the user. Each of the surfaces **304**, **308** and **310** may be prisms, holographic, active, passive, many layered, single layered, internal to the waveguide, external to the waveguide, etc. The example provided in FIG. **3** is merely exemplary in nature to help the reader understand that there are various types of waveguides with directional surfaces to manage the image light. Further to that point, while the illustrated configuration shows a particular arrangement and orientation of the image production module, the waveguide and the various surfaces, it should be understood that the inventors envision that there are other configurations that work and the configuration generally depends on the finished product's requirements.

(20) FIG. **4** illustrates a waveguide construction with vision correction and increased content density through controlled scene light transmission in accordance with the principles of the present invention. The inventors discovered that waveguides, while useful and a very good form factor for smart-glasses, are fragile because they are made of glass. They are also expensive, so breaking them in a pair of glasses is not good. In addition, because they are glass, any breakage could result in an eye injury for the user. The embodiment illustrated in FIG. **4** hardens the waveguide such that it is less susceptible to breakage and/or impacts. In addition, the embodiment in FIG. **4** provides a waveguide see-through augmented reality solution with a corrective vision element and increased content density due to the controlling of scene lighting that provides back lighting to content provided through the waveguide.

(21) The waveguide **302** of FIG. **4** is part of an assembly once the other components in the illustration are added. As illustrated, the several components stack together to form, at least a portion of, an example of an image transfer module **204**. The stack includes the waveguide **302** with an inner protective layer (e.g. polycarbonate, protective plate, etc.) **402**, which is on the user's eye **414** side of the stack. The stack also includes an outer protective layer (e.g. polycarbonate, protective plate, etc.) **404** on the opposite side of the waveguide **302**. In embodiments, an air gap **412** is maintained on each side of the waveguide **302** such that the waveguide operates properly. That is, the stacking of optical elements includes an air gap on both sides of the waveguide such that the total internal reflection nature of the reflections inside of the waveguide are not disrupted. The air gap **412** preserves the substantial index of refraction difference between the material waveguide **302** and the transition to the next material.

(22) The optical stack of FIG. **4** further includes a vision correction optic **410** (e.g. a molded elastomeric that sticks to the inner protective layer **402** through surface adhesion, a glass or plastic vision correction optic that is adhered to the protective inner layer **402**, etc.) The vision correction



optic is meant to correct the user's vision in the same way as other prescription lenses, but in this embodiment, it is placed on the inner protective layer **402** so it will correct the user's view of not only the surrounding environment but also the content presented through the waveguide **302**. In embodiments, the vision corrective optic **410** is a molded elastomeric that sticks to the inner protective layer **402** through surface adhesion. This allows for quick and easy application of a vision correction optic **410** that is made specifically for the user. An ophthalmologist, or other prescriber of corrective lenses, could make and sell correctives that could then be applied by the user by essentially sticking the optic onto an outside surface of the inner protective layer **402**. Of course, in situations where a prescriber is not required, the user may simply purchase a corrective and apply it to the inner protective layer **402** (e.g. a 'reader' optic for increased magnification). In embodiments, it is important to have a vertical and planar waveguide **302** and/or vertical and planar (e.g. planar at least over the surface where the vision corrective optic **410** is to be mounted) inner protective layer **402** positioned in front of the user's eye for the vision corrective optic **410** to work properly. When the waveguide **302** is positioned substantially vertically, image light transmits from the waveguide at substantially 90 degrees from the waveguide surface towards the user's eye. This is because typical vision corrective optics **410** are optically designed to be looked through when they are positioned vertically. This avoids needing to make a very complicated prescription on the vision correction optic **410** to compensate for the angle through which the user would be viewing. In an alternate embodiment, if the waveguide **302** is on an angle off of vertical, the inner protective layer **402** may include an angle on it's outer surface (i.e. closest to the eye **414**) or be mounted on an angle with respect to the waveguide **302** such that when the vision corrective optic is attached, it is vertical with respect to the user's eye **414**. In embodiments, the inner protective layer **402** may include one or more markings, or a template may be provided, to help a user with the alignment of the vision correction optic **410**.

(23) In embodiments, the inner protective layer **402** may itself include a vision corrective portion. The inner protective layer could be formed out of polycarbonate, or other suitable material, and shaped into the corrective prescription for the user. Then the vision corrected inner protective layer could be attached to the waveguide **302** such that the air gap **412** is preserved. This would eliminate the need for a separate material to be applied to the inner protective layer **402**. Of course, this configuration may require a more involved manufacturing or user process for installing the vision corrected inner protective layer **402**.

(24) As illustrated in FIG. 4, in embodiments, the stack may include an outer protective layer **404** that is positioned to provide an air gap **412** between the outer protective layer **404** and the waveguide **302** to preserve the proper total internal reflections of the waveguide when it is delivering computer content to the user's eye in a head-mounted see-through computer display. The stack may also include an electrochromic layer **408** that may be controlled by a processor in the head-worn computer **102**. The electrochromic layer may be computer controlled to quickly reduce or increase the amount of scene light reaching the waveguide **302**. The scene light essentially forms background light for the computer images presented in the waveguide **302** because of the see-through nature of the waveguide **302**. With high transmissivity on the outside of the waveguide **302** (i.e. the opposite side of the user's eye) computer content presented in the waveguide **302** may be transparent and/or require a high brightness for the content to overcome the scene light. With the electrochromic layer **408** activated to provide dimming of the scene light, the computer content may be less transparent and/or the brightness of the content may be reduced because there is not as much scene light to overcome. In embodiments, the electrochromic layer **408** is applied directly to the outer protective layer **404**. In other embodiments, the electrochromic layer **408** is applied to an intermediate layer.

(25) The inventors discovered that when applying electrochromic surfaces to glasses formats, there are significant difficulties. The electrochromic surface tends to not apply well to complicated shapes, including compound radiuses like a standard corrective glass lens or sunglass lens. It

becomes somewhat easier to apply the surface to a single curve in a surface. It is easiest and produces the best results when it is applied to a flat planar surface. In embodiments, the air gap design described herein may be used in connection with any shaped electrochromic surface.

(26) In embodiments, the outer protective layer **404** may include photochromic material(s). This would provide auto-dimming of the scene light based on the intensity of the scene light. A photochromic layer may be provided in a separate layer on either side of the outer protective layer. Typically, the photochromic layer would be positioned further from the user's eye than the electrochromic layer such that the electrochromic layer did not have an effect of the performance of the photochromic layer.

(27) In embodiments, anti-reflective coatings may be applied to any or all of the optical stack's surfaces illustrated in connection with FIG. 4 that are exposed to air in the final assembly to prevent reflections during use of the head-worn computer **102** to prevent distracting reflections.

(28) In embodiments, inner and outer protective layer **402** and **408** may be applied to the waveguide **302** without leaving the air gaps **412** by using a material for the protective layers that substantially matches the index of refraction of the material used for the waveguide **302**. By using an index matching material, the total internal reflection of the waveguide may use the outer surfaces of the protective layers. In such a configuration, an air gap may be provided between the inner protective layer **402** and the corrective optic **410**. Further, in such a configuration an air gap may be provided between the outer protective layer **404** and the electrochromic layer **408**.

(29) In embodiments, the waveguide **302**, or portions thereof, may be made of chemically treated glass to increase the waveguides strength (e.g. Gorilla Glass).

(30) In an embodiment, a head-worn see-through computer display, may include a glass waveguide having a first inner surface, the first inner surface having a planar area at least in a region where image light is projected from the glass waveguide towards an eye of a user, the glass waveguide further configured such that image light transmits from it at approximately 90 degrees as referenced to the first inner surface, a protective inner layer positioned between the glass waveguide and the eye of the user, wherein the protective inner layer is further positioned to provide a first air gap between the glass waveguide and the protective inner layer, and a vision corrective optic mounted on the protective inner layer and positioned between the protective inner layer and the eye of the user. The glass waveguide may include at least one holographic surface. The at least one holographic surface includes a plurality of holographic surfaces. The glass waveguide may be positioned vertically in front of the eye of the user. The protective inner layer may have an outer surface upon which the vision corrective optic is mounted and the outer surface may be positioned vertically in front of the eye of the user. The head-worn see-through computer display may further include a protective outer layer positioned on a waveguide side opposite the protective inner layer, wherein the protective outer layer may be further positioned to provide a second air gap between the protective outer layer and the glass waveguide. The head-worn see-through computer display may further include an electrochromic surface controlled by a processor to controllably block at least a portion of scene light from reaching the glass waveguide. The electrochromic surface may be positioned between the protective outer layer and the glass waveguide. The electrochromic surface may be applied to the protective outer layer and the second air gap may be between the electrochromic surface and the glass waveguide. The protective outer layer may be photochromic. The vision corrective optic may include an elastomeric optic that attaches to the protective inner layer with surface tension.

(31) Although embodiments of HWC have been described in language specific to features, systems, computer processes and/or methods, the appended claims are not necessarily limited to the specific features, systems, computer processes and/or methods described. Rather, the specific features, systems, computer processes and/or and methods are disclosed as non-limited example implementations of HWC. All documents referenced herein are hereby incorporated by reference.

## Claims

1. An optical stack comprising: a waveguide; a vision corrective optic disposed on a first side of the waveguide; a protective layer disposed on a second side of the waveguide; an electrochromic layer disposed on the second side of the waveguide; and an air gap disposed between the waveguide and the protective layer.
  2. The optical stack of claim 1, wherein the electrochromic layer is disposed between the waveguide and the protective layer.
  3. The optical stack of claim 2, wherein the electrochromic layer is coupled directly to the protective layer.
  4. The optical stack of claim 2, further comprising a substrate layer disposed between the electrochromic layer and the protective layer, wherein the electrochromic layer is coupled directly to the substrate layer.
  5. The optical stack of claim 1, wherein: the first side of the waveguide is configured to face a user, the second side of the waveguide is configured to receive scene light, and the optical stack is configured to present the scene light to the user.
  6. The optical stack of claim 5, wherein presenting image light to the user comprises presenting the image light via total internal reflection of the waveguide.
  7. The optical stack of claim 1, wherein the electrochromic layer is configured to adjust an amount of scene light presented to a user based on a control signal provided by one or more processors in communication with a wearable head device.
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